

Mycology Publishing Project

Immediate Next Artifacts | Enterprise presentation edition

PREPARED FOR INTERNAL ALIGNMENT AND PARTNER-READY PRESENTATION

Executive decision package and partner-ready briefing set

Prepared 28 March 2026 | Based on uploaded project materials available in-session

DOCUMENT NOTE

All substantive content from the supplied materials has been preserved and repackaged for executive readability, presentation use, and next-step execution. No external repository content was assumed beyond what was available in this session.

KYLE BRIEFING

Digest of the 27 March 2026 strategy call

This opening section is formatted as a handoff summary Kyle can read quickly before moving into the full artifact package.

CALL CONCLUSION The manuscript's problem is packaging and audience fit, not weak substance.	STRATEGIC REFRAME Treat the project as a two-track publishing property: Book A specialty physical + Book B digital/reference.
IMMEDIATE BLOCKER Rights clarity and artist alignment must come before production decisions.	EXECUTION POSTURE Use gates: edition strategy, rights, editorial conversion, layout prototype, then route-to-market choice.

- Original intent: a book for growers and farmers without a scientific background. Current reality: a manuscript that reads more like a scientific paper.
- Best solution identified on the call: split the project rather than overloading one format.
- The specialty physical edition should be visual, browseable, premium, and intentionally truncated. The digital/reference edition should retain the complete scientific depth and appendices.
- The existing David Carlson illustrations are a strategic asset. The team should avoid mixing visual styles and should re-engage the artist after internal alignment.
- Formatting is not the first task. The first task is deciding what each edition is supposed to do, then verifying rights and beginning a technical-accessibility edit.

EXECUTIVE TAKEAWAY

What changed in the call is not cosmetic. The project moved from “finish the manuscript” to “run a multi-edition publishing program.” That is the correct frame for every next decision.

Objective, current problem, recommended structure, risks, dependencies, immediate next actions, and unknowns

These fields convert the strategy discussion into an execution frame the team can actually operate against.

Objective	Convert a technically dense manuscript on fungal interactions with cannabis into a commercially viable, professionally structured, two-edition publishing property with clear editorial intent, visual coherence, rights safety, and route-to-market discipline.
Current problem	The manuscript is strong in substance but misaligned in form. It drifted away from the original non-specialist grower audience and now creates audience friction through density, academic framing, and unclear product identity.
Recommended structure	Run the project as two complementary products: Book A, a visual-forward specialty physical edition for discovery and browseability; and Book B, a fuller digital/reference edition that preserves scientific rigor and extended utility.
Risks	• Rights ambiguity for existing and future illustrations. • Visual incoherence if mixed art styles are introduced. • Oversimplifying the science while trying to improve accessibility. • Jumping into formatting before the edition model and rights framework are locked. • Choosing a publication path before clarifying what speed, control, prestige, and margin really mean for this team.
Dependencies	• Edition architecture approval. • Verified art licensing and attribution evidence. • Artist availability and appetite for expanded participation. • Manuscript audit by edition fit. • A primary route and a fallback route that both make sense for a two-edition program.
Immediate next actions	• Approve the artist outreach brief and email. • Locate and review image contracts, invoices, email permissions, and Carlson licensing references. • Map manuscript sections across keep / rewrite / cut / appendix / digital-only / diagram / sidebar. • Run a pilot technical edit of one representative chapter.

	Resolve the route scorecard discrepancy and choose a primary and fallback path.
Unknowns	- Exact rights scope for Carlson images and researcher-permission images. - Whether the artist wants deeper involvement, expanded commissions, or royalty participation. - Exact manuscript length, chapter breakdown, and page-budget implications. - Whether grant pathways are viable under the current entity structure and timeframe. - Which priority dominates when trade-offs emerge: speed, control, prestige, or margin.

Method note: the uploaded project summary explicitly states that SharePoint folder links were referenced historically but were not directly retrievable in-session. This document therefore uses the materials actually available in the current workspace.

ARTIFACT 1

Artist outreach brief and email draft

This section turns the artist conversation into a controlled business interaction rather than an informal check-in.

Task objective

Draft a professional outreach brief and accompanying email to engage the existing artist, communicate the repositioned two-edition strategy, clarify rights and scope, and open a structured conversation about expanded collaboration.

Confirmed facts	Assumptions	Open questions
Approximately eight to nine illustrations already exist from David Carlson and are considered high-quality and integral to the project's visual cohesion. The project is being split into two complementary editions: a specialty physical edition emphasizing images, and a fuller digital/reference edition retaining depth. Rights and licensing terms for existing artwork are not fully documented yet, and any further contributions may require negotiation. The team has no agent and plans to contact the artist directly once internally aligned.	The artist is still reachable and open to continued collaboration. He may be interested in deeper participation, royalty-sharing, or cover redesign, but this has not been confirmed. Existing usage rights are likely tied to the original manuscript context and need explicit confirmation for new editions and derivative layouts.	What are the specific licensing terms for the existing images — duration, scope, exclusivity, print rights, digital rights, and derivative use? Is the artist willing to expand the illustration package and participate in art-direction decisions? What compensation framework is realistic for additional artwork or a larger creative role?

Internal brief

- Why the artist matters: Carlson is not a replaceable vendor. His existing work is the strongest visual asset in the file set and the most natural foundation for Book A's visual system.
- Project state: the manuscript is being repositioned into two editions. **Book A will favor images, short-form explanatory copy, sidebars, and browseability. Book B will preserve technical depth, appendices, and reference utility.**
- What this conversation must accomplish: re-establish contact, acknowledge the value of the existing illustrations, explain the new edition model, invite discussion of additional commissions and art-direction involvement, and clarify existing rights without overcommitting on terms before internal review is complete.
- What not to do: do not promise specific compensation, royalty splits, credit titles, or production commitments in the first email. Do not imply that a publisher is already attached. Do not request new work before confirming rights status and general interest.
- Recommended budget posture for the first contact: mention that compensation and credit will be structured to reflect any expanded scope of work, but keep exact numbers off the first email unless there is a hard internal ceiling that must be disclosed immediately.

EMAIL DRAFT

Subject: The Mycology of Cannabis — Project Update and Expanded Collaboration

David,

I hope this message finds you well. I wanted to reach out because the Mycology of Cannabis project is entering a new phase, and your work has been central to how we think about the book's visual identity.

Since we last spoke, we've done a significant strategic reassessment of the project. The manuscript is strong, but we've concluded that the format needs to change. Rather than publishing a single text-heavy edition, we're repositioning the project as a two-edition publishing program: a physical specialty edition that leads with visuals and is designed for browsing, discovery, and shelf presence; and a fuller digital reference edition for serious growers, educators, and institutional readers.

The specialty edition is where your work becomes especially important. We want this book to feel like a single authored visual world — cohesive, premium, and unmistakably intentional. The illustrations you've already created are the strongest visual assets we have, and they're the natural foundation for the edition's entire art direction. We're not interested in patching together different styles or filling gaps with unrelated stock imagery.

What we'd like to explore is whether there's interest and availability on your end to expand your involvement. That could include clarifying the licensing and usage framework for the existing illustrations, discussing additional commissioned pieces, and considering whether there is a larger role for you in the book's visual direction, including cover treatment or style guidance.

I don't want to presume what the right arrangement looks like — that is a conversation we'd prefer to have together once you've had a chance to hear where the project stands and what we're building toward.

If you're open to it, we'd welcome a call or video meeting in the next couple of weeks to walk you through the current plan and discuss what an expanded collaboration might look like. No commitments on either side at this

stage — just an honest conversation about fit, scope, and timing.

Looking forward to hearing from you.

[Author name(s)]

[Role / organization]

[Contact information]

Decision gate	Approve the outreach brief, personalize the email, verify Carlson's current contact information, and decide whether budget specifics remain internal for the first exchange or are surfaced up front.
Inputs needed	• Copies of existing image contracts, invoices, or email correspondence specifying rights granted. • Any budget parameters or compensation expectations that should inform negotiation posture. • Confirmation of the preferred meeting format once the artist responds.
Next artifact	Artist Collaboration Plan: a one-page framework setting out deliverables, deadlines, compensation options, rights treatment for old and new work, and cover/credit responsibilities after the artist responds.

ARTIFACT 2

Edition architecture memo

This section defines the publishing architecture so editorial and production work stop chasing a moving target.

Task objective

Define the publishing architecture by detailing the role, target readers, format logic, and content scope for the specialty physical edition and the digital/reference edition.

Confirmed facts	Assumptions	Open questions
The manuscript was originally conceived for growers and farmers without a scientific background, but it became overly dense and structured like a scientific paper. Feedback indicates scientifically literate readers find it strong, but the broader audience finds it inaccessible.	Both editions will derive from a single manuscript but will require different editing, layout, and distribution strategies. Some material — especially deep appendices, citations, and technical passages — will live only in the digital/reference edition. Physical production costs and page	How long is the current manuscript, and what is the precise chapter breakdown? Which sections are essential for all readers versus specialized audiences? Are there distribution, compliance, or educational constraints that affect cannabis-related publishing in target

The discussion concluded that splitting the project into two complementary products resolves the tension between readability and rigor, aesthetics and depth, and broad reach versus niche authority. A digital/reference edition remains part of the desired outcome.	count have to be controlled, which favors curated content and high-impact visuals in Book A.	markets?
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Dimension	Book A — Specialty physical edition	Book B — Digital/reference edition
Purpose	Discovery product: premium, image-led, credible, browseable, conversation-starting.	Depth product: authoritative, searchable, fully rigorous, and useful for serious readers and institutions.
Working identity	The Mycology of Cannabis: A Visual Guide	The Mycology of Cannabis: Complete Reference
Primary readers	Growers, cultivators, dispensary professionals, curious practitioners, gift buyers, trade-show and partner audiences.	Commercial growers, educators, students, institutional libraries, and niche professionals who need the full material.
Reading context	Coffee table, farm office, break room, display shelf, event table, gift purchase.	Operational reference, coursework, training, library access, searchable digital use.
Format	Oversized hardcover, full color, roughly 120–160 pages, high image-to-text ratio, strong chapter openers and sidebars.	ePub and PDF reference format with optional print-on-demand; equivalent of 300–400+ pages with full appendices and navigation.
Editorial treatment	Condense, translate, restructure, and visually lead. Preserve scientific meaning, but reduce cognitive load through annotated diagrams, glosses, sidebars, and short-form explanatory copy.	Retain full manuscript depth, appendices, glossary, vocabulary guide, and citation apparatus; structure for searchability and practical reference use.

Content allocation

Content element	Book A	Book B	Treatment note
Narrative chapters on fungi–cannabis biology and cultivation relevance	Yes — condensed	Yes — full	Book A should use figure-led rewrites and shorter explanatory modules.
Carlson illustrations and feature visuals	Primary	Secondary	Book A uses the artwork as the visual spine; Book B includes it in support of the reference text.
Annotated diagrams and infographics	Yes	Yes	Created for accessibility in Book A, then reused in Book B.

Sidebars, callouts, chapter previews	Yes	Limited	These are major accessibility tools for Book A.
Taxonomic tables and deep appendices	No or summary only	Yes — full	Too dense for the physical specialty format.
Glossary and vocabulary guide	Abbreviated	Full	Supports browseability in A and reference utility in B.
Full bibliography and citation apparatus	No	Yes	Book A should use simplified attribution; Book B carries full scholarly support.

Audience and sequencing

- **Recommended release sequence: produce Book A first, then Book B. Book A is the proof of concept that demonstrates visual authority, market fit, and production quality. Book B should follow using the editorial and design infrastructure created during Book A production.**
- This sequence reduces risk. Book A has a tighter scope, lower page count, and clearer packaging logic. Publishing Book B first would front-load the hardest editorial and formatting work before the project has market-facing validation.
- The architecture also makes route-splitting possible: Book A can pursue a specialty trade or grant-assisted pathway while Book B remains compatible with digital self-publishing or future institutional licensing.

Dependencies and blockers	• Image rights must be verified and documented for Carlson artwork and researcher-permission images. • The artist relationship must be clarified before Book A art direction is treated as locked. • The Growers Guide derivative and earlier coffee-table planning notes need to be reconciled with this architecture so the project does not branch into competing derivative tracks. • The manuscript V4.0 needs a gap analysis against this content allocation so the team knows what is condensed, what is moved, and what is cut from Book A.
Decision gate	Approve or amend the two-edition architecture before any artist outreach, editorial conversion, layout prototyping, or publisher/funder engagement moves forward.
Inputs needed	• Complete V4.0 manuscript text for gap analysis. • Confirmed inventory of Carlson artwork with all supporting correspondence. • Growers Guide V1.2 and coffee-table planning documents for reconciliation. • Any updated publisher or funder contacts the team wants to prioritize.
Next artifact	Manuscript Audit Grid: a chapter-by-chapter tagging sheet marking keep, rewrite, cut, appendix, digital-only, diagram, or sidebar.

Rights and asset inventory synthesis

The uploaded workbook is already framed as the project's single source of truth. The task now is populating and validating it before partner outreach or production commitments.

Asset class	Current status	What is known now	Action required
Carlson commissioned illustrations	Verification required	The workbook logs approximately eight to nine commissioned illustrations and flags the original agreement / evidence trail as still needing to be located.	Locate invoices, emails, pricing references, and any written terms governing print, digital, derivative, and exclusivity rights.
Carlson stock art piece	Verification required	One stock-art item is separately identified, and the workbook notes that stock licensing may restrict edition scope.	Verify the stock license and whether Book A / Book B usage requires a different permission tier.
Researcher-permission images	Permission on file, scope TBD	The workbook lists signed or emailed permissions from Gauthier, Kapoor, White, Punja, Hiemstra, Volk, Kumar, Wang, and Brazeer.	Review each permission for print, digital, derivative, international, and expiration limitations.
Main manuscript files	Present but not reconciled	The workbook lists V4.0 as the current working draft, earlier archived versions, the Growers Guide derivative, glossary, vocabulary guide, and appendices A–E.	Confirm the actual current source files and tie each one to Book A, Book B, or archive-only status.
Publisher history	Historically documented, current viability unclear	Acres USA is listed as a signed 2022 contract that lapsed after ownership changes; Timber Press, Green Candy Press, and Chelsea Green are also logged with follow-up questions.	Review what was submitted, what feedback exists, and whether any of these publishers remain viable now under the revised product model.

RIGHTS PRIORITY

The rights workbook is not just administrative cleanup. It determines what the team is legally able to offer, reproduce, redesign, distribute, and negotiate across both editions. This should be completed before serious external outreach expands beyond the artist conversation.

ROUTE-TO-MARKET

Publishing route scorecard and decision tension

The route workbook adds rigor, but it also exposes a decision that should be made explicitly rather than implied.

Route	Weighted total	Strategic reading	Practical role
Specialty Trade Publisher	150 / 205	Highest raw weighted score in the workbook. Strong on production quality, discoverability, and prestige for Book A, with moderate compromise on control and rights.	Strong operational fallback or even primary path for Book A if speed and grant uncertainty matter more than full rights flexibility.
Grant-Assisted Hybrid	146 / 205	The recommendation sheet still names this the primary recommendation because it preserves more control and rights across the two-edition model.	Best strategic path if credible funding prospects can be qualified quickly and the team values long-term flexibility over near-term simplicity.
Self-Publish	133 / 205	Strong for control and revenue retention, weak for operational load, upfront cost, and specialty-edition distribution.	Viable for Book B and as a backup, but risky as the primary route for the illustrated physical edition.
Academic / Reference Publisher	121 / 205	Best for institutional prestige, weakest on speed and visual-forward flexibility.	Better as a future Book B option than as the lead path for the total program.

- Important executive note: the workbook's raw weighted totals rank Specialty Trade Publisher slightly above Grant-Assisted Hybrid, but the recommendation sheet still prefers Grant-Assisted Hybrid on strategic grounds because it better fits the two-edition architecture and rights-retention goal.
- That is not a problem — but it is a decision point. Leadership should either accept the recommendation despite the raw score gap, or revise the weighting logic so the numeric output and narrative recommendation align.
- Recommended posture right now: **treat Grant-Assisted Hybrid as the strategic primary only if the team can qualify real funding pathways on a short clock. Otherwise, the strongest operational fallback is Specialty Trade Publisher for Book A plus self-published digital/reference Book B.**

Decision gate	Choose one primary route and one fallback route before serious publisher outreach, grant applications, or production budgeting begin.
Inputs needed	• Completed rights and asset inventory. • Approved edition architecture. • A realistic internal view of speed, control, prestige, margin, and capital tolerance. • Any grant-eligibility constraints under the entity structure being contemplated.
Next artifact	Route Execution Plan: a gated timeline, budget range, outreach sequence, and owner map for the chosen primary and fallback path.

EXECUTION PLAN

30-day sequence and final decision checklist

The project becomes manageable as soon as every next action is tied to a gate, an owner, and a deliverable.

Window	Primary work	Output
Days 1–5	Approve the two-edition architecture, finalize the artist brief, collect all artwork and rights documentation, and resolve whether the first artist email stays high-level on compensation.	Approved architecture + approved outreach package + rights evidence file set.
Days 6–10	Send artist outreach, confirm current source-of-truth manuscript files, and build the manuscript audit grid.	Artist contact initiated + file inventory stabilized + audit grid ready.
Days 11–20	Run one pilot technical-accessibility edit and outline a five-to-eight-page sample spread set for Book A.	Editorial proof of concept + design brief for sample pages.
Days 21–30	Reconcile the route scorecard, qualify grant feasibility quickly, and choose a primary and fallback route.	Route decision + execution plan.

FINAL DECISION CHECKLIST

Before production begins, the team should be able to answer yes to all of the following: (1) the edition model is locked; (2) the rights position is documented; (3) the artist relationship and scope conversation has started; (4) the manuscript has been tagged by edition fit; and (5) the route-to-market choice has both a primary and fallback path.

Source basis used in this dossier: uploaded project summary + prompt pack, strategy call transcript, artist outreach brief, edition architecture memo, rights asset inventory workbook, and publishing route scorecard workbook.